

the launch of PlayStation 2 which was the first console to feature a DVD drive. The competition was between 4 major consoles- SEGA's Dreamcast, Sony's PlayStation 2, Nintendo's GameCube and Microsoft's new entry – the Xbox. The first 2 sixth generation consoles in the market, Dreamcast and the PlayStation 2 came with 128 bit era processing capabilities but that was not the only difference. The console developers started focusing on other aspects of the console too. Graphics processors were given more attention and RAM capacities were increased. Games were more beautifully designed and the use of DVD drives meant all the more space. Online gaming became a thing and a number of new titles were released that were going to turn into series that will go on for decades and generate a fortune for their developers.

Midway through the decade, the winners of the race were clear. Sony was on the top with its PlayStation 2 becoming one of the most sold consoles of all time, selling more than 150 million systems. Xbox enjoyed a mild success but their implementation of online gaming set a new trend. Nintendo was running a generation late and it was their 6th generation GameCube Console that featured an optical disc drive.

All in all it was an exciting time for both game developers and gamers. Companies were innovating, trying to win the loyalty of gamers with niche titles and new, interesting features.

Major Consoles

Let's take a look at the 6th generation consoles and see what they did right and what they didn't.

SEGA Dreamcast

Sega's Dreamcast was launched in 1998 in Japan followed by a 1999 launch in North America and Europe. Hoping to learn from the mistakes it made with Saturn, Sega marketed the console heavily and worked hard to bring down the overall cost of the console. Instead of using complex hardware that led to the high production cost of Saturn, Sega opted to assemble the console with off the shelf components which were commonly used in the personal computers of the time and this helped them bring down the cost significantly.

Also, instead of using CD or DVD ROMs, Sega worked on developing its own optical drive technology in collaboration with Yamaha Corporation. Dubbed the GD-ROM, it could store about a GB of data and cost almost the same as a standard CD. It also helped to check piracy, as most Dreamcast game couldn't be copied onto a 650 MB CD with all the features intact.